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Giang Nguyen-Thu

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Making life 'platform ready': care and platform economy beyond the multisided market

Giang Nguyen-Thu

School of Communication and Arts, University of Queensland, Brisbane, Australia

ABSTRACT

Existing scholarship on platformisation often explains the expansion of digital commerce via the lenses of 'multisided markets' and 'network externalities.' This article traces the limits of these formal categories to challenge the tendency to naturalise platforms as self-regulating market-makers. Drawing on long-term ethnographic fieldwork in Vietnam (2016–2025), it follows Vietnamese mothers who engage in Facebook – and TikTok-based online retail to map their evolving practices, struggles, and aspirations. My analysis reveals that long before TikTok Shop's celebrated fusion of content creation with direct shopping experiences, Vietnamese mothers had already laid the foundations that prefigured this model by crafting hybrid subjectivities of creator and retailer, cultivating logistical sensibilities, and generating a moral economy rooted in care. By foregrounding the feminised infrastructures that underpin digital commerce, this article invites an analytic shift from platform-centric logics toward the lived histories of social reproduction and everyday precarity that enable platformisation.

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Platform care; multisided market; network effects

One is not born an 'externality' …

Hương[1] welcomed me to her home tucked into Hanoi's sprawling outskirts on an early Friday morning in November 2024, her two sons' backpacks still slung over her arm after the kindergarten drop-off. Her living room, once spacious, had become a warren of cardboard boxes stacked precariously. 'It's not always this messy,' Hương said with a note of embarrassment as we picked our way toward a coffee table half-buried beneath packaging tape and bubble wrap. Hương usually filmed and livestreamed at home while renting a small place a few doors down for storage. But her warehouse was 'completely full now for the upcoming Monday Freeship sale.' Seeing my puzzled look, Hương added, 'I'm adjusting my product combos to fit TikTok's new freeship vouchers.'

After a cup of tea, we sat on the floor to do the packaging together when Hương walked me through the intricacies of being a TikTok seller while mothering two small sons. I learned that she had to repack numerous 'combos' by adjusting her price from '45,000 VND for two' to '105,000 VND for five' to align with TikTok's updated Freeship Monday Campaign. The campaign's premise was straightforward: TikTok offered a 45,000 VND free-shipping voucher for orders exceeding 100,000 VND on every Monday, which was better than previous vouchers for smaller combos. But this benefit came with layers of obligations. Hương had to give customers a 15% discount, of which TikTok subsidised 3%, leaving her to absorb the remaining 12%. TikTok would also deduct an extra 6% from her total sales for joining the program, on top of the standard 9.5% commission fee all sellers paid. She must also meet a strict logistical requirement: at least 95% of all

CONTACT Giang Nguyen-Thu t.nguyen72@uq.edu.au School of Communication and Arts, University of Queensland, St Lucia, QLD 4072, Australia

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orders had to be shipped within the same day, including Saturdays. This 'fast dispatch rate' (FDR) policy means that Hương had only a few hours after receiving an order to pack and hand it over to a TikTok's partnered delivery service for official scanning. Despite the additional cost and back-breaking shipping policy, she joined the program nevertheless, in exchange for 'boosted visibility' and promotional tags like 'Super Deal' and 'Extra Freeship.' 'It's tough,' Hương noted, 'but customers love vouchers, especially the free-shipping ones.'

Hương's story provides multiple *possible entry points* to understand the entanglement of digital platforms and social life. One could, for example, start with the platform itself, by investigating how a single freeship voucher, issued in a seemingly neutral manner by TikTok Shop, serves as a powerful catalyst for a cascade of interdependent actions among multiple actors: sellers, delivery workers, and buyers. For Hương, it compelled a reorganisation of her home into a site of intensified marketing and logistical labour, where filming, live-streaming, packing, and shipping dictated her daily and weekly rhythms, further tethering her to domestic space. She must remain at home more, working extra hours, adapting her movements to the platform's promotional cycles, managing logistical irregularity, while balancing childcare and household chores along the way.

The voucher's influence also extended beyond Hương's routine; it tied her business fate, quite literally, to the increasingly precarious lives of last-mile delivery workers, mostly men, whose schedules were monitored by TikTok Shop's logistics partners, each operating under their own set of opaque algorithmic control. Because 'customers love vouchers,' the Monday Freeship campaign would predictably fuel a surge in demand, further entrapping the delivery workers between sellers like Hương pushing for rapid same-day pickups of bulkier packages and buyers ravenous for their discounted goods. The pressure was particularly acute in Vietnam's cash-on-delivery (COD) market (Thế 2019) where Hương's pricier 'combos' translate into greater sums of cash collected with every successful delivery. Effectively turned into human-ATMs within the e-commerce ecosystem, the last-mile delivery workers must shoulder heightened risks of financial punishments from package mishaps – loss, damage, rejection – a vulnerability woven into their platformised mobility.[2]

If we start our analysis with the platform, we could conveniently rely on the well-established vocabulary of platform studies in explaining the platform's market-shaping power. Consider, how TikTok Shop's voucher system exemplifies a widely discussed, and often taken as self-evident, feature of digital platforms: their role as intermediaries that facilitate the so-called 'multisided' markets by aggregating and leveraging different cohorts, or 'sides' (Egliston and Carter 2022; Helmond 2015; Rieder and Sire 2014). Here the power of a platform lies in its capacity to bring together two or more groups of agents through strategic pricing, so that 'the benefit enjoyed by a member of one group depends upon how well the platform does in attracting custom from the other group' (Armstrong 2006, 1). This matchmaking role generates the famous 'network effects' or 'network externalities,' where 'more agents on one side bring more agents to the other side(s),' thus increasing the value of the network (Gürkaynak et al. 2017, 105). Once these 'effects' take hold, they create a powerful lock-in, making it costly for all 'sides' to leave the platform, since exiting would mean abandoning accumulated connections, reputational capital, and market access. The result is that, 'network effects are extolled as the single most powerful escalating platform dynamics, and growing the network, at virtually any cost, is the chief maxim of the platform economy' (Grabher and König 2020). Platformisation, from this perspective, is essentially the process of internalising 'external' sides into a monetisable architecture of managed interdependence.

As in the case of Hương, TikTok Shop deploys the Monday Freeship campaign to offset delivery costs for buyers while capturing their attention through a stream of free and captivating short-video content. Via this subsidising strategy, TikTok Shop amasses an expansive customer base of 67 million Vietnamese users by 2024 (Statista 2024), enticing sellers and content creators like Hương to join, despite mounting costs. With order volumes growing exponentially, last-mile delivery becomes essential, making it easier for men to find jobs amid widespread post-pandemic unemployment, but harder for them to handle the ever-heavier workload once they are already 'locked-in.' Beyond viewers, buyers, sellers, content creators, and delivery workers, TikTok Shop also

engages other 'sides,' including brands, advertisers, multi-channel networks (MCNs), payment providers, add-on designers, and so on. Seen as a facilitator of multisided market, TikTok Shop's success rests on its capacity to strike a complementary balance, where one 'side' sustains the other, thereby turning cross-side connections into dependency, dependency into retention, and retention into profit through strategic pricing and subsidies.

In the above explanation, the concepts of 'multisided market' and 'network externalities' perform powerful abstraction, one that flattens messy and open-ended social and economic processes into the sanitised language of 'sides' and 'effects.' Discussions of power and dispossession, profit and loss, governance and alterity could then proceed in abstract universality without having to articulate what the 'externalities' actually involve. Used critically, these formal concepts might help expose the platform's gaze: one that casts the entire world as resources readily available to be internalised by its profit-making system. Yet when treated as self-evident and deployed as a dominant mode of description, these concepts end up centralising the platform as a self-regulating market-maker, while abstracting away the rest, inadvertently reinforcing the very mechanism they purport to critique.

Instead of starting with the platform as a self-referential and disembedded system, what happens to our analysis of platform economy if we shift our entry point to the so-called 'externalities' – the delivery workers who wrestle Hanoi's chaotic streets, or the TikTok sellers, like Hương, who transform their homes into digital factories? Consider, how a simple visit to Hương's home draws us into the vast, unruly world that lies beyond the platform's frame of recognition. This world encompasses not only Hương and her delivery workers, but also Hương's domestic life – shared with her children, husband, and cats – as well as Hanoi's labyrinthine streetscape, and Vietnam's sluggish reliance on the cash economy. Stretching further, we might even include the endless rainy days during the week of my visit, which likely drove up TikTok Shop traffic by keeping people from outdoor shopping. We should also take into account the risks endured by delivery workers navigating the immanent threat of flooding and the choking pollution of Hanoi's early winter, not as marginal anecdotes, but as the operational condition of the infrastructure that keeps the platform running (Nguyen-Thu and Munn 2024). Because these human and non-human factors – each enmeshed, within thick webs of infrastructural relations and everyday contingencies – are framed merely as passive 'externalities' awaiting platformisation, TikTok Shop alone took credit for what Vietnamese journalists hailed as 'miracle speed' ('*thần tốc*') when it captured nearly 30% of Vietnam's online market in 2024, swiftly rising into the country's second-largest e-commerce platform in just ten months (Đỗ 2025; Ngọc 2023).

A change of an entry point does not herald a romanticised shift in power dynamics; instead, it gestures toward a more complex narrative that challenges the platform-centric approach – a different kind of 'multisidedness' perhaps. Here I draw on Anne Helmond's influential idea of 'platform readiness' (2015), developed in her analysis of how social media platforms extend their programmability to the web to make external data 'ready' for platform extraction. Yet I propose shifting this analytic lens toward the broader sociocultural terrains to trace how situated lifeworlds – time, space, bodies, aesthetics – are gradually reconfigured into a condition of platform readiness. What matters here is the sociocultural work of translation and reframing that renders life increasingly available for digital capture and vulnerable enough for the harsh terms of platformisation to appear tolerable, if not aspirational. As I shall elaborate, this process of reconfiguration is inseparable from grassroots tactics of care and creativity beyond platform's intention or effects. Once we start attending to the 'externalities' – 'the outside' that makes digital speed possible (Duclos 2017, 25) – it becomes rather obvious that TikTok Shop's 'miracle' rise in Vietnam is less a triumph of platform design than a reflection of the improvised, enduring, and friction-filled labour of those left at its disposal.

Changing our point of departure in thinking about the platformised situation demands a methodological sensibility that braids critique with care. This sensibility urges us to see how people on the ground are not only victims but also world makers at the edge of platform logics. As Pollio and

Cirolia (2024, 158) remind us in their study of platformisation in Africa, we should pay attention not only to the predatory logics of digital optimisation but equally to 'the kinds of mundane ameliorations that platform processes yield in the context of inconvenient systems.' This different entry point signals a refusal to conflate the fragile condition of grassroots viability with a lack of significance, also a refusal to grant platform capitalism an inherent rationality or treating its enclosing power as singular or inevitable. In this way, we could study platformisation without being drawn into its autopoietic mechanism, instead exploring it as a leaky and unfinished process, held together precariously by the very infrastructures, labour arrangements, and everyday negotiations that the language of market-making often abstracts away.

Drawing from long-term ethnographic research in Vietnam since 2016, this article traces how a specific form of economic-cultural subjectivity and its associated lifeworld, rooted in care, logistical improvisation, and maternal labour, gradually took shape, and later got captured into TikTokShop's 'network externalities.' Conceptually grounded in economic anthropology, the article draws on Anna Tsing's insight into the constitutive link between cultural diversity and global capitalism, Michel Callon's concepts of 'framing' and 'overflowing,' and the overall Polanyian critiques of market formalism to interrogate how platformisation emerges not simply from technological innovation or self-regulating market evolution, but from lifeworlds made 'platform-ready' through long histories of precarisation and adaptation.

In what follows, I set the context for the rise of TikTok Shop in Vietnam before elaborating on my conceptual and methodological framework. I then centre the figure of the online petty-trading mother to examine how certain lifeworld becomes 'platform-ready.' I argue that in their entrepreneurial migration from Facebook to TikTok Shop, mothers are far from passive recipients of platformisation. Instead, they act as infrastructural subjects whose labour prefigures the blending of digital content and commerce later institutionalised by TikTok Shop. These practices are not simply dictated by platform architectures but crystallised through everyday negotiations with precarious conditions: rising anxieties over food safety, mounting burdens of care, crumbling social support, and the creative mobilisation of kinship-based logistics.

In this context, the platformisation performed by TikTok Shop is not just a textbook case of multisided market but also of erasure: formalising what mothers had already built while stripping it of context, reciprocity, and negotiated control. Shifting our attention toward what actually constitutes platform's 'externalities' thus enable us to see how platform power stems not only from preying on existing precarity but also from the care-based infrastructure that underwrites platform scalability and speed. The article thus calls for a reorientation within platform studies by moving sideways from its overt platform-centric focus to take into account the grounded practices that not only sustain platform economies but also exceed and unsettle their enclosure.

Setting the scene of content-driven e-commerce

In 2020, Douyin – the Chinese social media platform previously known for its vibrant short-video culture – began embedding a shopping cart within eligible videos and livestreams, backed by a comprehensive transactional infrastructure, including payment options, marketing packages, and logistical arrangements. In doing so, Douyin repositioned retailing as the ultimate purpose of content production, and quickly disciplined its content creators to 'focus only on metrics rather than on social relationships' (Huang and Ye 2024, 677). TikTok – Douyin's twin under the same parent company – copied this model and applied it internationally.

In Vietnam, TikTok adopted this retail-oriented model in 2022 by launching its retailing feature, called 'TikTok Shop', to promote 'highly immersive shopping experiences' (Zhang et al. 2024, 34). This retailing expansion took place amid TikTok's rapid consolidation in Vietnam, where the platform attracted nearly 40 million users by 2022 and added another 20 million by 2024, putting it on par with Facebook (Statista 2024). As detailed in the story of Hương, the new retailing feature

enables TikTok to extract value at every node along the content – commerce circuit: data, visibility, traffic allocation, advertising, and even last-mile delivery.

What TikTok Shop brings to the global digital economy is a hybrid model of *content-driven e-commerce*, branded as the 'shoppertainment,' where short-video platform doubles as a retail interface. This model differs significantly from that of Facebook and YouTube, in which content creators are usually not directly involved with retail transactions. Rather than fostering a more or less merit-based environment for creative expression, Douyin and TikTok's algorithms increasingly tie a creator's success to their capacity to sell products embedded in their videos. The value of content is no longer determined by its creative quality or cultural significance, but by the creator's capacity to prove themselves worthy of traffic allocation through the conversion of views into sales. As a result, content creators are increasingly subject to 'a standardised assembly line of production […] at the expense of innovation and diversity' (Huang and Ye 2024, 650). This shift toward a 'fierce monetisation campaign' (Su 2023, 94) marks a significant departure from the earlier quasi-democratic ethos of social media that linked 'visibility' (Abidin 2016) to content quality, which upheld, at least rhetorically, the promise of creative freedom. In this 'post-visibility' era of platformisation (Wang 2025), everything online is for sale.

Because TikTok Shop's self-branded 'shoppertainment' model requires a fully developed ecosystem to ensure transactional and logistical flows, especially in negotiations with regulatory scrutiny by local governments (Le 2023; Tobin and Nindita 2024), TikTok Shop has only been rolled out selectively, despite the global popularity of its content-first version. The shopping interface was rapidly launched arcoss Southeast Asia and the UK (2021), then the US (2023), and recently Ireland and Spain (2024). Southeast Asia – particularly Vietnam, Indonesia, Thailand, and the Philippines – thus served as the pioneer international testbeds for the 'shoppertainment' model, where it gained widespread adoption and remarkable success. In Vietnam, TikTok Shop's rapid ascent is particularly striking when compared to Shopee and Lazada – the two leading e-commerce platforms, both without a social media component – which took more or less a decade to establish their dominant positions in the Vietnamese market.

Yet again, if we remind ourselves that 'network externalities' are made rather than given, then TikTok Shop's remarkable success in Vietnam could serve as less a milestone than a social diagnosis: by 2022, Vietnam had reached a new threshold of 'platform readiness.' This readiness is not simply a matter of technological uptake or consumer enthusiasm. Rather, it reflects deeper social and economic shifts that have made it increasingly normal, and even necessary, for everyday life to align with the imperative of platformised convenience (Neves and Steinberg 2024) and more importantly with its intensified extractive logics. Put differently, TikTok Shop's success reflects a broader habituation to instant buying and selling within social media streams, and also the degree of socioeconomic precarity that renders the exhausting demands of content-driven e-commerce acceptable for individuals like Hương and her delivery workers to endure.

Investigating how Vietnamese life had become 'ready' for TikTok Shop's remarkable success in the early 2020s thus requires a return to the preceding years – those that saw the gradual formation of hybrid subjectivities that blurred the line between content creator and online retailer. We also need to attend to the gradual emergence of a moral economy in which social media becomes naturalised as a space of commerce, alongside the cultivation of logistical sensibilities that tune everyday life into a continuous stream of digital retailing. Against the dominating discourses of novelty and disruption, my analytical stance echos Adrian Athique's call (2019a, 68) for an evolutionary approach in platform studies, which 'allows us to situate 'platform capitalism' as a phenomenon emerging from the extension and convergence of long-term tendencies in media markets.'

The focus on 'long-term tendencies in media markets' is where my sustained ethnographic engagement with online petty-trading mothers in Vietnam enters the analysis. Throughout the 2010s, these mothers played a pivotal, yet often overlooked, role in shaping a condition of platform readiness when they reworked Facebook's communicative affordances into retailing infrastructure that blurred the line between content and commerce. In doing so, they effectively performed what

TikTok Shop would later formalise: the doubling of social media into a transactional interface. But before we turn to the figure of the online mother, it is necessary to step back and specify how to conceptualise a shift away from a platform-centric perspective to foreground the historically situated actors and practices typically framed as 'externalities.'

Social media between culture and economy: an ethnographic approach

If 'externalities' is not a neutral 'network effect' but the very conceptual mechanism that enables the abstraction of the broader lifeworlds into sites of platform extraction, then denaturalising 'network externalities' demands us to rethink where a multisided market begins (or ends). This question of market boundary, or the unsettling formation of the 'internal' and 'external' domains of the market, has long occupied economic anthropology and sociology, especially in their foundational debate about the relationship between 'economy' and 'culture.' This debate is most evident in the formalist – substantivist division in understanding the economy (Grabher and König 2020; Granovetter 1985; Hann 2021; Polanyi 2001). While formalists understand markets as self-regulating systems driven by rational optimisation, substantivists argue that markets are fundamentally shaped by social relations and local contingencies.

Expectedly, critical scholarship on platform economy aligns with the latter, portraying platforms not as autonomous infrastructures but as sociotechnical assemblages shaped by technological shifts, cultural imaginaries, and material infrastructures (Athique 2019a; Gillespie 2010; Steinberg 2019). Yet, much research in platform studies continues to treat platforms as internally coherent systems, privileging their quasi-autonomous technical architectures and market-making models while giving limited analytic attention to their socio-cultural and geopolitical embeddedness.

Consider, how the disproportionate emphasis on 'internal' platform mechanisms over 'external' socio-cultural embeddedness subtly resurfaces in Poell, Nieborg, and van Dijck's influential review of the field (2019). In outlining the contour of platformisation, they propose a framework grounded in three major dimensions: data infrastructure, market multisidedness, and platform governance. They also suggest, somewhat tangentially, that cultural studies should examine the fourth dimension: the embeddedness of digital platforms in the social world. As they state, 'what is notably absent is how platforms transform cultural practices, and conversely, how evolving cultural practices reshape platforms as specific socio-technical constructs' (2019, 5). This 'absence' is telling: while the concept of 'multisided market', borrowed uncritically from business scholarship, has become what Rieder and Sire term 'crucial resources for argumentation' in the political economy of platformisation (2014, 208), 'cultural practices' remain peripheral, acknowledged yet treated as secondary to critical analysis of platform-centric processes, despite the overall consensus that platforms are 'specific socio-technical constructs.'

The cultural approach, too, is implicated in their own set of blind spots and reductions regarding the platform economy. While investigating the operations of platformisation, cultural studies is often absorbed into the problem of styles and subjectivities. The tendency is evident across a wide range of work on intersectional self-representation (Duguay 2019; Ye, Dong, and Kavka 2023), micro-resistance (O'Meara 2019; Treré and Bonini 2024; Wood 2021), affective labour in conjunction with the cultural politics of visibility (Abidin 2016; Ge 2024; Yalin 2024). Even in studies directly involving e-commerce, discussions of self-presentation and everyday resistance often proceed without much attention to the embedded economic or logistical arrangements that shape these practices in fundamental ways (see, for example, Ye, Dong, and Kavka 2023; Zhao 2024; Zou 2018). In this way, cultural analyses tend to cast subjectivities as consequential rather than constitutive of platform economy, inadvertently reinforcing the reduction of involved actors and relations to mere 'effects' of platformisation.

The task of moving past what Zelizer (2012) terms the impasse between 'structural reductionism' and 'cultural absolutism' becomes urgent when we take seriously the fact that platform capitalism derives its strength from an unprecedented capacity to weave economic transactions into the fabric

of sociocultural diversity (Athique 2019b). It is in this light that Tsing's (2009a) invitation to trace the economic 'bigness' of global supply chains through the cultural 'smallness' of local diversity gains renewed relevance for understanding the variegated terrains of platform capitalism, which only further intensifies the conversion of 'the vicissitudes of gender, race, ethnicity, nationality, religion, sexuality, age, and citizenship status' (158) into sources of profit. Platforms thrive not only by absorbing cultural differences but specifically by preying on *the diversity of vulnerability* itself. These vulnerabilities, locally manifested in legal ambiguities, entrenched gendered and racialised labour patterns, and social support erosion, become *the* condition for platform expansion (van Doorn 2022). Understanding why and how Vietnamese mothers engage with the platform economy therefore thus requires close attention to the specific forms of sociocultural precarity and improvisation that make platform-based livelihoods the most viable 'way-out' for these caregivers despite instability and exploitation.

Analytically, Zelizer's concept of 'relational work' proves particularly instructive in unpacking how vulnerabilities are lived and navigated with digital platforms in the case of the mothers, especially in revealing the co-constitution of economic practices and mothering subjecthood. As Zelizer (2012) proposes, 'relational work' refers to the ongoing effort people make in cultivating viable matches among economic actions, transactional intermediaries, and meaningful interpersonal ties. Central to this approach is the idea that economic transactions are always social, formed through the careful calibration of social membership, media, and meanings, which together constitute what Zelizer (2012) refers to as 'relational package.'

As I will elaborate in the following sections, mothers' adaptation of Facebook into an informal marketplace involved the gradual construction of a 'relational package' composed of three interwoven elements. First, they cultivated a *hybrid subject position* between content creator and retailer on social media, which allowed them to generate modest cash flow while remaining at home to fulfil care duties. Second, mothers developed *logistical relations* to streamline the flow of platform-based retail transactions. And lastly, they built and sustained extensive online *communities* that normalised and habituated their retailing practices into a culturally and morally acceptable way of life. In these ways, mothers actively configured the intertwining of content and commerce on social media, generating a condition of 'platform readiness' upon which TikTok Shop would later exploit.

Regarding methodology, this paper takes an ethnographic stance, grounded in the commitment to understanding platform economies as historically lived realities rather than formal categories. If, as Tsing argues, 'supply chain capitalism *demands* an ethnographic approach' (2009a, 363, original emphasis), then such an approach is even more urgent in the times of platform capitalism, where the entanglement of datafication and local differences increasingly transforms diverse life-worlds into flexible circuits of accumulation. Here ethnography functions not merely as a method but as a central mode of inquiry (Abolafia 1998) – one that traces the co-constitution of cultural and economic practices in pushing against the 'false grails of inherent market logics' (Miller 2002, 232).

When my fieldwork began in July 2016, Vietnamese mothers had already played a substantial role in transforming Facebook into a vibrant online marketplace (Nguyen-Thu 2022), years ahead of the slow uptake of Shopee (Southeast Asia's largest e-commerce platform, entering Vietnam in 2016) and the post-pandemic 'miracle speed' of TikTok Shop. It should be noted that as more e-commerce platforms joined the Vietnamese market in the late 2010s, online retailers began experimenting with multihoming, juggling multiple accounts across platforms to navigate algorithmic volatility and generate diverse income streams. Many of the mothers I know had run retail accounts on Facebook for years before expanding to Shopee and, later, TikTok Shop, while Lazada – another major regional e-commerce platform – remained a less popular option. Mothers also relied on messaging apps, especially Zalo and Facebook Messenger, to sustain their informal retail businesses. The practice of multihoming reflects the inherently improvisational and fragmented character of e-commerce labour, especially among caregivers who try to spread risk across platforms but remain unable to scale up their business on any particular site. Still, because the two e-commerce platforms Shopee and Lazada were centred on product listings

without social media features, Facebook was the pioneering space where the hybridity of content and commerce first emerged and consolidated into the dominant mode of online shopping in Vietnam, well before the arrival of TikTok Shop's 'shoppertainment' model.

My methodological design adopts a non-digital-centric approach to the digital (Pink et al. 2016), or more specifically, a non-platform-centric one, where platforms are understood in their embeddedness within material, sensory, and cultural lifeworlds. Inspired by Precarity Lab's call for situated digital studies (2019, 80), I avoid taking for granted formal categories of platform economies, focusing instead on 'deep engagement with the yearnings, lived realities, and aspirations that intertwine in contradictory and ambivalent ways various positionalities' in digital times. My ethnographic practice follows five research routines outlined by Postill and Pink (2012, 128): catching up, sharing, exploring, interacting, and archiving. Specifically, I befriended mothers, joined their online trading networks, visited their homes, sustained conversations, collected oral histories, and analysed the digital content they publicly shared.

Since 2016, I have kept a research diary documenting my encounters, online and offline, with the so-called 'online petty trading mothers' (*các mẹ bán hàng online*), initially on Facebook and later TikTok Shop. My intermittent field trips since 2016 have collectively amounted to nearly three years of in-person immersion. To date, I have met and built in-person relationships with over 30 mothers – six active on TikTok Shop, the rest on Facebook. Most of the mothers I have engaged with were in their late twenties or early thirties when we first met. The depth of our connection varies, from one-off café conversations to home visits and sustained engagements (sometimes including my informal role as their children's English mentor). Given my commitment to nuanced, relational ethnography, this paper centres on the stories of Hương and Quỳnh – the two mothers with whom I have built sustained relationships. Their stories are triangulated with archived screenshots and other data from my engagement with relevant online communities to illuminate patterns of economic, cultural, and logistical improvisation. While Hương's and Quỳnh's experiences are singular, their experience resonates strongly with the broader configurations through which mothers navigate viable livelihoods amid the overlapping demands of care-based precarity, digital hustle, and platform dependency.

Tracing the precarious foundation of the platform economy

To understand mothers' formative role in shaping the digital circuit of content and commerce in Vietnam, we must consider three interrelated yet distinct social conditions tied to the precarity and creativity later folded into TikTok Shop's model. These include: the rise of Facebook in the early 2010s; the heightened anxiety around chemical-laden food linked to post-Reform industrial agriculture; and a growing sense of abandonment among young mothers navigating the competing demands of work and care.

Let us turn to the story of Quỳnh, one of my long-term interlocutors, who began selling 'clean oranges' (*cam sạch*) on Facebook in 2012 when she was in her late twenties. As she recalled, the decision arose during her maternity leave, following a straightforward economic calculation: 'My basic salary during maternal leave was close to nothing, and my husband's job at a state-run research institute brought in very little.' During her six-month leave from her position at an import-export company, Quỳnh started sourcing 'clean' oranges from her hometown in central Vietnam and mobilised her interpersonal networks to sell them on Facebook. What began modestly soon gained traction. Within months, demand grew enough that she hired a university student as a part-time delivery worker to help manage the rising volume of orders. And so, while remaining precarious herself, Quỳnh effectively became a 'small boss.'

Quỳnh did not return to work after her maternity leave, choosing instead to stay home with her child while continuing to sell oranges online. This decision marked a significant turning point, one she unpacked in far more details than her earlier explanation of the initial 'experiment' with Facebook retailing, revealing motivations that went beyond economic calculations. First, 'Facebook was

free,' and there was stable demand for 'clean food' (*thực phẩm sạch*) with a decent profit. Second, logistics and quality control were already in place. With her parents' help in her hometown, she had steady access to 'trustworthy' orange farms. Her parents also handled shipping via interprovincial buses. Third, and most importantly, Quỳnh 'wanted to stay at home with the little boy for a longer time.'

When I met Quỳnh in 2016, four years had passed since the day she launched her Facebook business. She had given birth to the second child and expanded her retailing beyond 'clean oranges' to baby products informally sourced through interpersonal networks in the US, UK, and Australia. These so-called '*hàng xách tay*' ('hand-carried goods') were items she had used for her own children before introducing them to her online store. Over those four years, her Facebook business not only sustained her growing family but also allowed her to stay by her father's side during his final months, a memory she recalled several times with quiet gratitude. By 2025, when this article is written, her store has shifted entirely to selling 'hand-carried' cosmetics, baby formulas, and health supplements from the West. 'It's getting harder to find chemical-free orange farms,' she explains, 'and my mother is now too old to help.'

Quỳnh's remarkable resourcefulness in the role of a mother, a daughter, a wife, and a rural migrant to the capital city, all crystallised in her decision to turn to Facebook-based retailing, is far from exceptional. Rather, her story reflects a recurring pattern I observed among many interlocutors. Facebook became an optimal 'choice' for mothers like Quỳnh only amid mounting care-work impasses, which were not only financially punishing but also affectively saturated. Precarisation pressed from both economic and cultural fronts: the widespread concerns over food safety amplified by relentless media alarmism; the double burden of raising small children while caring for ageing parents; the rising costs of education and healthcare; the disillusionment with ever-thinner social support that reinforced a narrative of 'self-reliance'; and, above all, the deeply moralised pressure to meet middle-class expectations of intensive mothering, so that, as Quỳnh put it, 'my children feel loved.'

The emphasis on mothers' self-reliance resonates with the broader welfare debates in Vietnam where, as Luong and Nguyen (2023) elaborate, both pro-business and pro-worker arguments ultimately converge on the same neoliberal ethos of self-responsibility. More importantly, post-reform Vietnam's labour and welfare structure is characterised by 'thin layers of social protection with labour regimes that are increasingly based on precarious and flexible work' (Luong and Nguyen 2023, 187). For mothers like Quỳnh, the convergence of the rhetorics around self-responsibility and the rise of platform-based livelihoods is thus far from coincidental. This dynamic demonstrates how post-Reform welfare retrenchment and platform capitalism operate hand in hand by disguising structural abandonment as the outcome of individual choice.

Here the relational texture of care, caught between material necessity, cultural expectations, and emotional intensity, makes visible how economic actions on platforms are never abstract models but affective forms of everyday attachment. Mothers' platform work is saturated with cultural knowledge and maternal care, including intuitive familiarity with what counts as 'clean food,' everyday anxieties transformed into compelling Facebook 'content,' and the unpaid labour of grandparents, aunties, and uncles quietly sustaining logistical needs. Within this moral economy, where care and commerce are deeply entwined, platformisation appears not as a rupture but as an extension of the longstanding gendered precarisation of social reproduction (van Doorn 2022). It is precisely this entanglement of economic threats and cultural obligations that draws mothers into the informal world of Facebook-based retailing, where, paradoxically, the very precarity they seek to escape becomes their most compelling selling point (see Figure 1 for an example).

The fact that the Vietnamese online marketplace emerged first and foremost from caregivers' anxieties about food safety thus underscores the need to attend to the affective and embodied forms of precarity that substantially shape the contours of platformisation. Only by grasping the depth of precarity surrounding food safety in Vietnam, especially for mothers of small children and caregivers more broadly, could we understand why, in a country where flea markets and



Figure 1. Screenshot of a public Facebook post, dated 7 December 2013, created by a mother who continues selling food on Facebook as of 2025. In this post, she promotes her homemade kimchi, describing it as 'delicious and clean, with all ingredients carefully selected by myself to be as fresh as possible.' She addresses potential customers as 'các mẹ ơi' ('hi mums'), a popular vernacular among 2010s Facebook users. The phrase 'các mẹ ơi,' often used even when addressing the general public (Nguyễn 2014) reflects how mothers came to dominate not only online marketplaces but also broader social media discourses, especially in feminised domains like lifestyle, education, celebrity, and health.

home-based kiosks line nearly every street, Facebook-based networks came to be seen as the 'smarter' marketplace for daily food: oranges, kimchi, vegetables, and baby products (such as baby formula 'hand-carried' from Australia, as seen in Figure 2). Here, mothers drew from the very collective anxiety surrounding food to sell food, and in so doing, they find themselves reproducing the same atmosphere of insecurity from which they had hoped to break free.

Worlding an online marketplace: subjects, logistics, and communities

Certainly, precarisation alone does not automatically make life 'platform-ready.' It takes time to build a lifeworld in which 'online shopping' (*mua hàng online*) feels like a 'natural' and desirable thing to do when one uses social media. This work of worlding involves crafting particular subjectivities, whose digital transactions are not merely economic exchanges but expressions of attachment to a specific mode of being in the world. To borrow E. P. Thompson's famous argument about industrial capitalism in the UK, the rise of e-commerce, too, requires the making of a 'new human nature' (1967, 57): one that adjusts to the tempo of digital immediacy and adapts to increasingly volatile conditions of not only consumption and entrepreneurship, but life itself. Or, in Michel Callon's terms, the emergence of the online marketplace depends on the ongoing



Figure 2. A public Facebook post, dated 17 September 2012, from a mother whose online store sells baby formula 'hand-carried by airline waitresses' from Australia. She writes: 'The price might be a little higher, but you dear mums could rest assured about its quality.' After the 2008 baby formula scandal in China, social anxiety over infant and toddler milk intensified in Vietnam due to the countries' shared border, fuelling a still-thriving online marketplace where baby formula is informally imported from Western countries through airline workers and kinship networks.

'construction of calculative actors' (1999, 190) whose market-driven sensibilities are formed alongside and in constant negotiation with the moral framing of how digital transactions ought to be logistically organised and culturally interpreted.

In terms of subject formation, what marks mothers' distinctive position in the early 2010s online marketplace is their hybrid role as *both* content creators and petty retailers. This hybridity was not supported by any single platform at that time, but emerged through mothers' improvisation against care-based precarity, as detailed in the case of Quỳnh above. While individual retailers could start opening their own stores on Lazada in 2013 and on Shopee in 2016, these two platforms offered mainly static product listings with limited interactivity, and Shopee introduced livestreaming

features only in 2024 to compete against TikTok Shop. Meanwhile, influencers on content-first platforms, such as Facebook, Instagram, and YouTube, often endorse products for a commission, but typically do not engage directly in selling or order fulfilment.

Mothers, by contrast, operated across both domains of online content and commerce. In fact, mothers' hybrid subjectivity anticipated a broader structural shift that started gaining traction in the late 2010s, when content-driven platforms like Facebook, YouTube, and Instagram began integrating retail functions to enable direct shopping experiences, albeit with limited success, until the recent rise of Douyin Shop in China and TikTok Shop globally. As early as 2012 (Figures 1 and 2), Vietnamese mothers already crafted 'authentic' content on Facebook to sell products while also managing the entire retailing process, from sourcing to delivery. Petty trading on Facebook could yield relatively quick returns, yet often modest, so long as mothers maintained an active network of Facebook 'friends' that sustained a small customer base. Unlike influencers whose labour centres largely on content production, mothers' online performances are inextricably tied to physical and logistical labour: sourcing products, overseeing quality, storing inventory, packaging, and arranging deliveries. Their homes thus often serve as micro-warehouses, and their work routines are shaped by a logistical sensibility of endless coordination between online and offline, care and work, emotional labour and physical strain, digital speed and infrastructural delays.

Take the issue of last-mile delivery, for example. By the early 2010s, the surge in informal online retail had transformed delivery work into a distinct category of casual labour, often carried out by unemployed male acquaintances or university students seeking flexible income (Thanh 2012). Extensive Facebook groups that matched online sellers with suitable delivery workers were mushrooming in these years, before any last-mile delivery platforms joined the Vietnamese market. Among the mothers I interviewed, there was a constant preoccupation, at times frustration, with the logistical burden of arranging and maintaining delivery capacity. Far from the trope of 'immaterial labour,' every additional order comes with a proportional increase in logistical labour of both mothers and their delivery partners, which defies digital abstraction and undermines the fantasy of infinitely scalable platform productivity.

Mothers' unique position between content and commerce involves holding in tension the digital velocity of online exchange and the logistical slowness anchored in material constraints and care obligations. In other words, the viability of mothers' self-invented business model – their 'relational package' in Zelizer's terms – hinges on a delicate manoeuvre between maintaining online visibility and coordinating messy backstore processes, so that their platform work stays compatible with caregiving routines while still delivering the appearance of seamless digital transactions to customers. In grappling with the imperative of digital convenience, mothers act as improvising configurators of what Neves and Steinberg (2024, 26) call 'the logistical surround,' where 'ordinary experience is reorganised and becomes newly logistical' in processes of platformisation. Operating at the world-building level, mothers' 'relational package' exceeds any single platform, progressively reconfiguring life itself into infrastructures for digital commerce across space, time, bodies, and aesthetics.

By 2015, a full-fledged moral economy around online 'clean food' had taken shape in Vietnam. This moment coincided with major infrastructural shifts. Facebook had surpassed 30 million active users, soon dominating the Vietnamese cultural and political discourses (Nguyen-Thu 2018). At the same time, last-mile delivery services like Giao Hàng Tiết Kiệm and Grab were slowly formalising gig logistics. Online bank transfers were also increasingly normalised for everyday transactions.

By resourcefully adapting and coordinating these transformations, mothers' digital presence expanded quickly and was widely recognised. Facebook groups dedicated to mothers' online retailing proliferated in the mid- to late-2010s, functioning as self-organised marketplaces grounded in caregiving identities, affective trust, and shared moral commitments to clean, safe, nature-oriented consumption. Among the most prominent Facebook groups was *Chợ Quê* (Countryside Market), which grew to over a million members by 2019, most of whom were mothers of young children (Figure 3). Countless posts in this public group began with 'Hello sisters, I am a mother of milk and diapers … ' By creating content this way, mothers framed their retail work not as a business

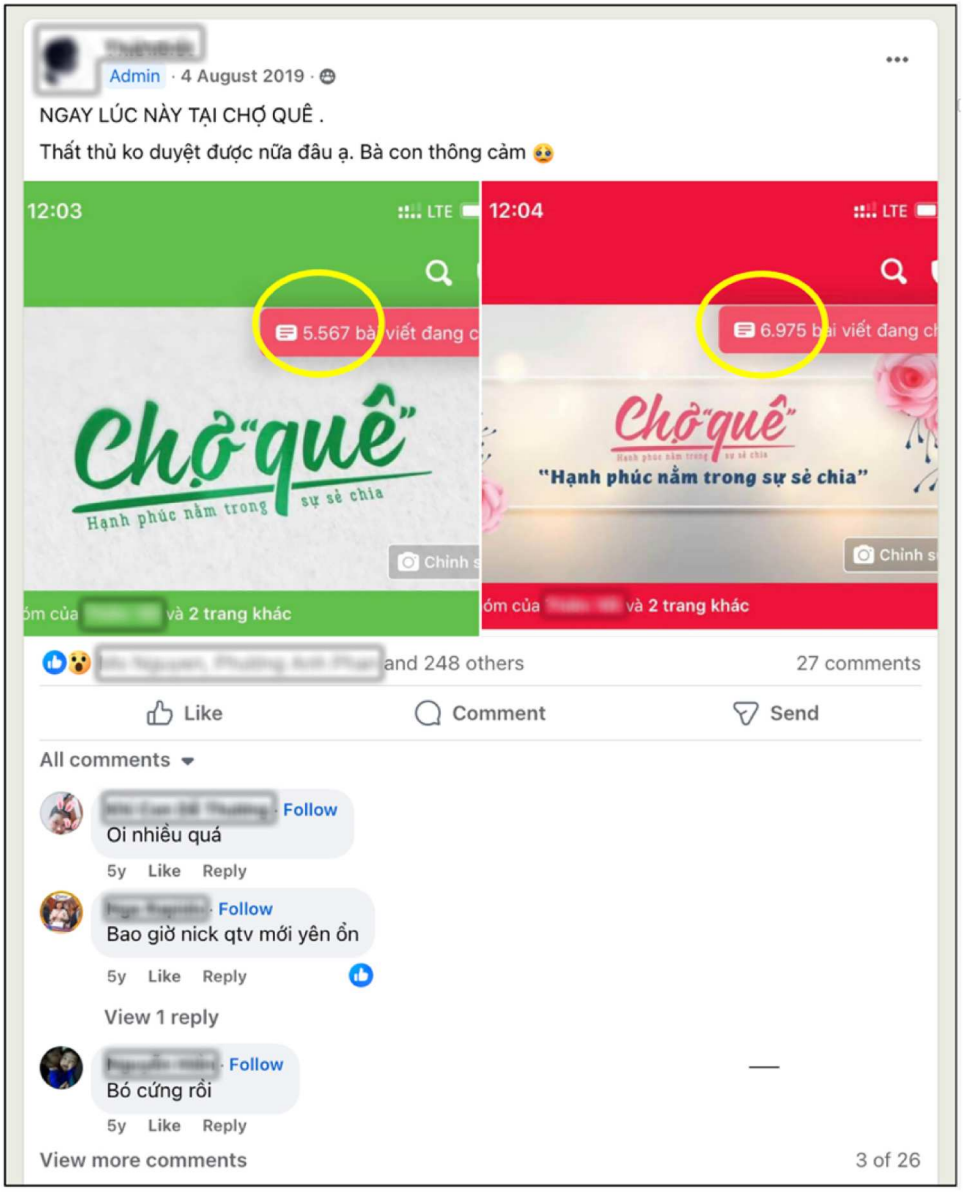


Figure 3. Screenshot of a Facebook post in the Chợ Quê group, where the admin expresses her team's exhaustion and appeals for sympathy from group members, noting that over 12,500 posts were waiting in the approval queue. At that point in 2019, this group had more than 1.2 million members.

venture but an extension of maternal care to 'earn a few extra pennies to feed my baby' or to 'share the cost and the opportunity of eating clean produce.' Group admins, almost all mothers, became powerful gatekeepers in approving posts, enforcing norms, and managing activities. These admins often used their gatekeeping power to promote their own food chains. Though participation in these groups was free, the admins usually charged undisclosed fees for an 'auto-approval right,' creating internal hierarchies of visibility and access. By 2018, these informal groups were already coordinating exchanges at the scale of millions, leveraging informal infrastructures to match buyers and sellers via creative content in ways that prefigured the cross-side logics later institutionalised by platforms like TikTok Shop.

It is important to keep in mind that the way Vietnamese mothers repurposed Facebook's communicative affordances for home-based retailing was neither anticipated nor engineered by Facebook itself. As a result, their improvisational labour was never fully 'captured' within Facebook's formal profit-making strategies. Facebook's core revenue model has long depended on advertising, with retail remaining a marginal and largely unsuccessful avenue of monetisation. Although Facebook launched Marketplace in 2016 and introduced Facebook Shops in 2020, these new retail interfaces attracted little interest from Vietnamese mothers. Most continued to operate through their personal profiles, largely independent of Facebook's designated e-commerce features. This resistance was largely due to the disjointed and restrictive nature of Facebook's e-commerce interfaces, which separated product listings from the interactive flow of everyday posting. Facebook's constant nudging for paid advertisements also placed additional pressure on small-scale retailers, who lacked the capital to compete for algorithmic visibility through sponsored content. To maintain their informal trading networks and increase sales, mothers instead mobilised chat functions, Facebook groups, and practised multihoming across platforms such as Zalo (messenger app), Shopee, Instagram, and TikTok.

In fact, many mothers believed that Facebook sought to suppress their informal retail activities because the platform could not monetise mothers' online activities. Since 2019, both the mothers I spoke with and members of popular Facebook groups have voiced concerns that Facebook was increasing its 'screening' activities (*quét*) and limiting the visibility of users who sold products without buying advertisements. In response, mothers concertedly avoided explicit sales language to evade algorithmic detection. For instance, in many posts I observed, *bán* ('to sell') was written as '*b.á.n*,' while '*nghìn*' (one thousand Vietnamese dongs) was replaced with '*cành*' (literally 'tree branch,' used symbolically to indicate a small unit). Again, this camouflage strategy, rooted in mothers' collective 'algorithmic imaginary' (Bucher 2017), illustrates how mothers' informal 'business model' emerged largely outside of, and in many ways, resisting Facebook's algorithmic control.

In his instructive work on the performative nature of the market, Callon (1998) introduces the concept of 'framing' to designate the construction of boundaries of what counts as a market, and 'overflowing' to capture how external forces, such as social, scientific, or environmental concerns, intrude upon and reconfigure those boundaries. From this perspective, while Facebook built tools to 'frame' mothers as an 'externality' in their supposed roles as a particular kind of user or retailer, mothers' practices consistently 'overflowed' these boundaries, taking root instead in care, kinship, and improvisational logistics. In this sense, it was the mothers that effectively transformed Facebook into a productive 'externality' of their own home, rather than simply being absorbed into Facebook's internal multisided-market logic. The point here, of course, is not to romanticise the difficult choices imposed on mothers when they turned to Facebook for a livelihood, as discussed above. Rather, mothers' everyday ameliorations reveal not only what Callon (1998, 18) terms the 'impossibility of total framing' but more importantly, the generative power of vernacular infrastructures in shaping the platform economy from below.

Conclusion: beyond 'network externalities'

With the rise of TikTok Shop's tightly integrated content-commerce infrastructure in 2022, Facebook's informal retail ecosystem began to wane. The choice to sell goods via Facebook, once praised as a smart, low-cost, and flexible entry into entrepreneurship in the early 2010s, now feels increasingly obsolete, more akin to traditional flea markets than digital innovation. Informal groups of Facebook retailers like *Chợ Quê* are no longer bursting with activities, especially when Facebook is increasingly associated with an ageing demographic. Mothers, once pioneers of the online retail space, now struggle to keep pace with the scale and speed of the post-COVID platformisation.

In our most recent video call in March 2025, Hương, the mother introduced at the beginning of this article, complained to me that TikTok Shop had been intensifying its 'blood-sucking' (*hút máu*)

policies. This bleak metaphor, interestingly enough, still rested on the assumption of TikTok Shop being 'smaller' than society rather than the other way around. With another commission fee increase scheduled for 1 April 2025, on top of the strict same-day dispatch policy, Hương planned to switch to affiliate marketing on TikTok and return to Facebook to run her small beef jerky store 'as before.'

Ironically, the much harsher conditions imposed by TikTok Shop have retroactively cast mothers' already strenuous lives under the 'Facebook era' in a more forgiving light. Yet we should resist the temptation to lapse into nostalgia. The point is that when mothers began repurposing Facebook for retail in the early 2010s, they were able to forge a level of reciprocity that tapped into an earlier imaginary of social media as more 'networks' than 'platforms' – a space associated with ideas of 'openness, freedom, and rhizomatic extensivity' (Steinberg 2019, 22), instead of 'fierce monetisation' (Su 2023, 94). Through their improvisation, mothers effectively reconfigured Facebook into a more or less 'care-compatible' infrastructure, bending a global platform toward their own situated needs in ways entirely unintended by Facebook itself.

More importantly, even when TikTok Shop increasingly displaces mothers who fail to withstand the new speed of social commerce, the feminised infrastructures they once built continue to shape the aesthetic, affective, and logistical contours of Vietnam's platform economy. Take, for example, the headline-making scandal of 2025 that involved three prominent influencers – 'hot mum' Hằng Du Mục, Quang Linh Vlogs, and beauty queen Thùy Tiên. On TikTok and Facebook, the trio promoted a fibre gummy product with a contested claim that a single serving matched the nutritional value of a whole plate of vegetables. Over 100,000 bottles were sold before the team was exposed and arrested for misleading product endorsement (Lê 2025). Beneath this viral success-turned-scandal was a familiar structure: a mother-led sales team, a trust-based narrative about health-related products, and a moral economy that lent social legitimacy to online figures through shared vulnerability rooted in care and vernacular authority. This moral economy also includes the completely hidden labour of thousands of last-mile delivery workers who shoulder the physical toil that makes the 100,000-bottle sale appear frictionless. What once emerged from grassroots coordination has now been formalised and monetised at scale (and, some might say, scam) when platforms, major brands, and elite influencers orchestrate the game. Yet the fact that today's platform economy still runs on the feminised infrastructures first improvised by mothers, while rendering those very mothers increasingly expendable, serves as a useful reminder that platforms' success has never been sustained on their own market rationality alone – a point of analytic intervention this article seeks to foreground.

So far, I have argued that platformisation in Vietnam is neither a top-down technological imposition nor a self-generating market evolution, but a historically situated process, deeply rooted in everyday precarity, adaptation, and care. Well before TikTok Shop's celebrated 'network effects' materialised, Vietnamese mothers had already performed the groundwork of making life 'platform-ready by transforming care into commerce, homes into warehouses, and kinship networks into infrastructural resources. In so doing, these women actively prefigured the 'shoppertainment' model now powerfully institutionalised by TikTok Shop. In the gradual shift of online retailing from Facebook to TikTok Shop, the relational openness once cultivated by mothers is increasingly displaced by structural closure. Mothers are now rendered as mere 'externalities,' caught in a system that demands everything while offering little in return.

'No firm has to personally invent patriarchy, colonialism, war, racism, or imprisonment, yet each of these is privileged in supply chain labour mobilisation,' writes Tsing (2009b, 151) on how supply chain capitalism relies on cultural diversity for its super-exploitation, especially in the Global South. In much the same way, platforms do not need to create gendered precarity, care burdens, informal labour patterns, and kinship networks, yet they depend on these existing sociocultural conditions to function while abstracting them as 'externalities.' Rather than reverting to the inside – outside binary, it is the platform's liminal edge that demands our critical attention – a threshold where creativity, adaptation, and exploitation bleed into one another in unsettling ways.

From this perspective, the multisided market is not merely a site of equivalence in exchange value; it remains, in many ways, a gift economy, where economic practice is inseparable from social ties. As my interlocutor Quỳnh put it when speaking of her once thriving 'clean orange' business, 'Facebook is free' – a perceived 'gift' from digital networking that Quỳnh, in turn, passed forward to her father and her children during their most vulnerable moments. 'Gifts' are also given by grandparents and extended kinship networks, as well as group-based support that infuses the lifeworld of online marketplace with meanings and dignity beyond economic instrumentality. We often fail to recognise these gifts precisely because of the ways we separate markets from its constitutive lifeworlds, leaving us unable to grasp the open-ended social relations that sustain market transactions.

How we, as scholars, choose to frame what counts as a 'multisided market' thus matters, because without acknowledging the erasing power of our conceptual moves, we risk reproducing the very structures we intend to critique. So, if 'not all ties can be cut' in the making of markets, as Callon (1998, 18) reminds us, then our task is to attend more carefully to what lies beyond the formal boundary of the 'platform economy.' In orienting ourselves toward the troubling edge between markets and lifeworlds, this approach, rooted in care, may offer a viable path for imagining how this system might one day be effectively overflowed.

Notes

1. All names have been changed, and all translations are mine.
2. In a platform economy heavily reliant on cash payments like Vietnam, requiring delivery workers to collect money for most delivered packages has, at times, led to tragic outcomes. For example, on 17 January 2025, a delivery worker in Da Nang was beaten to death after being perceived as nagging too much for a US$15 cash payment. The public was shocked to learn that, with each successful cash collection, he earned 4,000 Vietnamese dong (15 cents) in commission, but failing to do so led to a hefty penalty of 500,000 dong (US$19) (Truong 2025).

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